GENDERED INSECURITY AND GENDERED RELATIONS WITHIN THE ARMY

> Many times we were starving; we didn't have enough food and we didn't have enough clothes. ... It was very cold, and we have to take clothes from the dead Burmese soldier because we couldn't afford new clothes, and it was also very difficult to find military colors for the uniforms. We used to dye white fabric with forest leafs to make it green, but the color would not last in the rainy season so when it rained, our bodies became stained.[9]

Despite the hard work endured by women to support the uprising, women's participation in the armed struggle in Myanmar is depoliticized by a gendered narrative that frames women's duties as domestic (for example, nursing, cooking), thereby relegating women's support of and involvement in political violence to the private sphere (Ferguson 2013; Hedström 2015b; Tharaphi Than 2014). In this way, dominant gendered divisions of labour are reproduced in the armed conflict. This public/private dichotomy then serves to rationalize the exclusion of women from public decision-making roles in the country. For example, with only a few notable exceptions, women have not been invited to participate in the ceasefire talks that began in 2011 (Hedström 2013). Similarly, within the KIO/KIA, women's inclusion is circumscribed by gendered norms: women are prevented from participating in combat, despite the fact that every woman interviewed for this research expressed a wish to fight on the frontlines alongside male soldiers:[10]

> I want to be a very brilliant fighter in combat, but as a woman I cannot go ... When I was in the [Defence Academy] the other woman cadets and me demanded 'let us go to the battlefield' because a lot of our school mates, the male soldiers, went to the battlefield but we were left behind at the school.[11]

By excluding women from combat, traditional family values are maintained. These values see women as the cultural and biological reproducers of the nation, but not as able to represent or protect the nation per se. Men are instead positioned as the primary defenders and protectors of both women and the community. Women's involvement is structured around feminized duties, such as cooking, sewing, and nursing, a gendered division of labour that serves to depoliticize women's involvement by placing it in the private sphere and trivializing the fact that the armed struggle is dependent on women's labour and participation. This is reinforced by the idea that women serving in the KIA should retire